

tries. The good news is that it is not as lethal as SARS or the Avian flu and survival rates are high.

Battle plan: A national helpline and Internet advice service launched. Advertisements on hygiene; every household will receive an advisory leaflet in coming days. Year and 1.7% next year	 MEXICO Casualty: 142 deaths, 16,019 cases reported. Economic cost: GDP to drop by 0.3-0.5%	 CHINA 1 death and 5,636 cases reported. Extreme measure of strict quarantine. Thousands of international visitors locked up; strict testing at airports and border crossings. GDP may be affected by 1% Figures for Mexico and China are up to July 30, 2009
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What are the SYMPTOMS?

- Sudden fever (100.4F or above), sore throat, runny nose, sneezing, coughing, headache, aching joints and chills.
- In a unique departure, a lot of patients get no fever.
- Diarrhoea, which is usually not seen in seasonal flus, is a unique symptom here.

Does OBESITY raise swine flu risk?

For the first time ever in an epidemic, people who are obese but otherwise healthy are found to be at special risk of severe complications from H1N1, US researchers report.



Is it more DEADLY than other flues?

It's behaving like seasonal influenza. But it's more contagious. The secondary infection rate—a measure of its spread—is between 20 and 30 per cent, whereas regular flu is less than 10 per cent. The avian flu and SARS were more deadly but did not easily infect humans as H1N1 does.



killed at least a million globally. Four decades are long enough to forget the lessons of the past, long enough for a viral strain to disappear and long enough for a new generation to grow up without any immunity to pandemic strains. But researchers know that if a pandemic of 1918 virulence were to arrive in today's interconnected world, it would cause havoc.

A World Bank study estimates that such a pandemic would leave perhaps 70 million dead. And another by Murray and Lopez in the medical journal, *Lancet*, 2006, puts the figure to 62 million, with 96 per cent of fatalities in the low and middle-income countries. No wonder, the medical community is nervous: "We have a new virus in the world that appears to be very contagious between people, and pos-

THE GRIEVING MOTHER OF SHRUTI GAWDE, A 13-YEAR-OLD H1N1 VICTIM, IN PUNE.

sibly between swine and humans. It is, fortunately, treatable with antiviral drugs Tamiflu and Relenza (oseltamivir and zanamivir), but it is resistant to the other major class of anti-flu drugs. It is still evolving, and moving, and its ultimate trajectory cannot be seen right now," says Dr K.S. Reddy, head of the Public Health Foundation of India.

Though the facts are still hazy, unanswered questions are flying about: could it turn into a global killer? How should governments respond when faced with a potentially devastating threat? And what lessons do we need to learn in the fight against swine flu?